

Natchez Trace Parkway

Lower Trace Self-Guided Cycling Tour
Natchez, MS → Rocky Springs, MS
Your route. Your pace. Your adventure.

TOTAL DISTANCE	DURATION	DIFFICULTY	BIKE TYPE	BEST SEASON
~82 Miles	See itinerary	Beginner	E-Bike	Spring / Fall

ESSENTIAL INFORMATION

START POINT	Natchez Visitor Center, Natchez, MS (Milepost 0)
END POINT	Rocky Springs Campsite, MS (Milepost 54.8)
RESUPPLY	Natchez (start), Port Gibson (MP 39.2) — stock up, limited options between
CASH	Bring cash — many small towns and local restaurants are cash only
CELL SERVICE	Spotty in many sections — download offline maps before departing
TRAFFIC	No trucks or commercial vehicles ever permitted on the Parkway
WATER	Available at NPS visitor centers and campgrounds — carry 2L minimum
EMERGENCY	NPS Ranger Station: (601) 446-6672 · Call 911 for emergencies
LODGING	B&Bs; and small inns — see recommendations per day below

ROAD SURFACE & CONDITIONS

SURFACE	SHOULDER	TRAFFIC	E-BIKE	RATING
Smooth asphalt	Paved · 3-5 ft	Very Low	✓ Suitable	Excellent

The Natchez Trace Parkway is NPS-maintained and among the smoothest roads in the Southeast. Asphalt is well-maintained with no chip seal. The shoulder is consistently wide and paved for most of the route, with no commercial traffic ever permitted. One of the most bicycle-friendly paved roads in the US.

YOUR BIKE TYPE	Ideal. All surfaces within e-bike capability. Check tire pressure before Rocky Springs.
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CONDITION EXCEPTIONS — Know Before You Ride

■ MP 0.0-1.2	Town Traffic	Brief section through Natchez city streets before Parkway begins. Watch for signals and car doors. Rejoins dedicated Parkway at MP 1.2.
■ MP 10.3	Emerald Mound — Gravel Parking Area	Turnoff has a short gravel parking area (50 ft). Main Parkway unaffected. Fine at any tire width.
■ MP 30.0-32.0	Windsor Ruins Detour — No Shoulder	Rodney Rd to Windsor Ruins is a narrow 2-lane county road with no shoulder and occasional vehicles. Ride single file, stay right. 1.5 miles each way. Worth every foot.
■ MP 39.2	Port Gibson Town Roads	Short section of city streets to reach lodging. Low traffic. Some cracked pavement typical of small-town Mississippi.

■ MP 41.0-45.0	Slight Surface Roughness	This 4-mile stretch shows more weathering than route average. Rideable on any tire, slightly rougher. NPS scheduled for resurfacing.
■ MP 54.8	Rocky Springs — Unpaved Campground Access	Campground access road is unpaved gravel and hardpack (~0.3 miles). Fine for hybrid and e-bike tires. Road bikes with 25mm tires should walk this section.

SEASONAL NOTES — SPRING

March–May is peak season. Wildflowers are spectacular. Book B&Bs; 6+ weeks ahead. Insects emerge in April — pack repellent. Mornings can be cool (40s°F), afternoons warm (70s°F). Best overall window: mid-March to early May.

GETTING THERE & LOGISTICS

YOUR TRIP Leave your car at the Natchez Visitor Center (free, secure NPS lot). Arrange a return shuttle to pick you up at Rocky Springs on your final day, or have someone drive your car to meet you.

BIKE SHIPPING BikeFlights.com ships your bike to your hotel and back home. Starts around \$60 each way. Book 1–2 weeks ahead.

E-BIKE NOTE E-bike riders: confirm charging availability when booking lodging. All recommended B&Bs; below can accommodate e-bike charging. Rocky Springs NPS campsite has no power — plan battery accordingly.

DAY 1 — ARRIVAL & NATCHEZ EXPLORATION

Arrive in Natchez — one of the oldest cities on the Mississippi River. Spend the afternoon and evening exploring before your ride begins tomorrow.

MILE	CUE / LANDMARK	DIR	NOTES
—	Natchez Bluffs	Walk	Stunning Mississippi River overlooks. Best at sunset.
—	Antebellum Mansions	Tour	Stanton Hall, Longwood, Dunleith — book tours ahead in spring.
—	Downtown Natchez	Explore	Historic Main Street, local restaurants, shops.
—	Overnight: Natchez	—	See lodging recommendations below.

DAY 2 — NATCHEZ TO PORT GIBSON (~42 miles · ~2,100 ft)

Your first day of riding begins at the Natchez Visitor Center. The Parkway wraps you in forest and calm immediately. Keep eyes open for deer, wild turkey, and armadillos in the early miles. Smooth NPS pavement, light car traffic, and your pace entirely your own.

MILE	CUE / LANDMARK	DIR	NOTES
0.0	Natchez Visitor Center — START	Head N	Parking, restrooms, water. Official Parkway start.
1.2	Under-the-Hill area	Continue N	Optional last coffee/food stop before the Trace.
10.3	Emerald Mound	Turn R	MUST STOP. 2nd largest Native American mound in US. Sunrise here is magical. Allow 30 min.
15.5	Mount Locust Historic Inn	Continue N	Oldest remaining inn on the Old Natchez Trace. NPS interpretive site.
17.5	Loess Bluff	Continue N	Unique geological formation. Short walk to overlook.
25.0	Sunken Trace	Continue N	Walk the original sunken trail worn by centuries of foot traffic.
30.0	Grindstone Ford / Mangum Mound	Continue N	Ancient mound and creek crossing. Good shaded rest stop.
35.0	Coles Creek Picnic Area	Continue N	Good lunch stop. Restrooms and water available.
39.2	PORT GIBSON — END DAY 2	Exit L	Turn left toward town. Motels and B&Bs.; RESUPPLY HERE for Day 3.

DAY 3 — PORT GIBSON TO ROCKY SPRINGS (~40 miles · ~2,400 ft)

Today features the single most memorable detour on the Lower Trace — the Windsor Ruins. Plan extra time. The day ends at Rocky Springs, a ghost town slowly reclaimed by forest, where the free NPS campsite sits among ruins of what was once a community of 2,600 people.

MILE	CUE / LANDMARK	DIR	NOTES
0.0	Port Gibson — START DAY 3	To Pkwy	Stock up food and water. Limited resupply ahead.
1.0	Re-enter Natchez Trace Pkwy	Head N	Resume from MP 39.2. Continue northbound.
41.0	Windsor Ruins Turnoff	Turn LEFT	MUST STOP. Onto Rodney Rd — 0.5 mi to ruins. 23 haunting columns in the forest. Allow 45-60 min.
41.5	Return to Parkway	Turn RIGHT	Rejoin Parkway heading north after Windsor Ruins.
45.7	Sunken Trace (2nd section)	Continue N	Original deeply worn trail. Short walk, very worth it.
47.5	Coles Creek Picnic Area	Continue N	LAST WATER before Rocky Springs. Fill all bottles here.
50.0	Owens Creek Waterfall	Continue N	Small but lovely waterfall. Easy 2-min walk off road.
54.8	Rocky Springs — END	Turn R	Free NPS camping. Water at site. Ghost town ruins and 1837 church nearby.

RECOMMENDED GEAR FOR E-BIKE TOURING

CATEGORY	ESSENTIALS	NICE TO HAVE
Bike	E-bike with minimum 60-mile range, spare tube, pump, multi-tool	Spare charger, portable battery pack for emergencies
Charging	Standard charger, confirm outlet access at each lodging in advance	Extension cord (6ft) — useful if outlet is not near bike storage
Food & Water	2x bottles minimum, snacks for the day	Electrolyte tabs — e-bikes still make you sweat
Navigation	Offline maps downloaded (Google Maps or Gaia GPS), this cue sheet	Garmin or Wahoo GPS with GPX loaded
Clothing	Padded shorts, jersey x2, lightweight rain jacket, arm warmers	Chamois cream, sun sleeves for hot days
Safety	Front and rear lights, helmet, ID, emergency contacts, basic first aid	Personal locator beacon for remote sections
Other	Cash \$50+ minimum, sunscreen, insect repellent (essential spring)	Small padlock for bike at overnight stops

NAVIGATION & DIGITAL MAPS

RESOURCE	HOW TO USE	WHERE TO GET IT
GPX File	Import to Garmin, Wahoo, Komoot, Ride with GPS, or Apple Maps	Included in your download from openride.bike
Ride with GPS	View interactive map, turn cues on your phone, export GPX	ridewithgps.com — search OpenRide Natchez Trace
Google Maps Offline	Download the region over WiFi before your trip	Open Google Maps → find area → tap Download
NPS Parkway Map	Official map with all mileposts, facilities, campgrounds marked	nps.gov/natr — free PDF download
Komoot	Excellent cycling-specific routing and navigation app	komoot.com — search Natchez Trace

This route guide was curated by a professional bicycle tour guide with over 10 years of experience leading tours on the Natchez Trace Parkway. Every stop, every note, and every recommendation comes from real miles ridden on this road.

Questions or feedback? Visit openride.bike — and share your ride photos with #OpenRide.